

# **Data Management Policy**

## **Harikar Organization**

### **2025**



**Revision 1: December 2025**

## **1. Introduction**

This Data Management Policy outlines the principles and practices that Harikar Organization follows to manage, protect, and govern data and information assets. The policy applies to all types of data both hard copies (physical documents) and soft copies (digital data) generated, collected, or received by the organization in the course of its operations.

Maintaining the confidentiality, integrity, and availability of information is critical to our accountability, operational efficiency, and the protection of beneficiaries, staff, and partners.

## **2. Objectives**

- a) Ensure accurate, secure, and accessible data management systems.
- b) Prevent unauthorized access, loss, or misuse of data.
- c) Promote transparency and accountability in data handling.
- d) Comply with donor requirements, legal obligations, and best practices.

## **3. Scope**

This policy applies to all staff, volunteers, consultants, and partners who handle Harikar's data, including:

- a) Programmatic data
- b) Administrative records
- c) Human resources and payroll data
- d) Beneficiary information
- e) Financial and procurement records
- f) Donor and partner communications

## **4. Data Management Principles**

Harikar adheres to the following principles in managing data:

### **4.1 Confidentiality**

All sensitive data especially that of beneficiaries, staff, and partners is treated as confidential and is only accessible to authorized personnel.

#### **4.2 Integrity**

We ensure data accuracy and completeness by implementing regular checks, backups, and version controls.

#### **4.3 Availability**

Information must be accessible to authorized users when required for programmatic or operational purposes.

#### **4.4 Compliance**

Data handling is aligned with applicable laws, donor requirements, and internal procedures, including GDPR like principles when relevant.

### **5. Hard Copy (Physical Document) Management**

- a) All hard copies are stored in locked cabinets or secure rooms with controlled access.
- b) Sensitive documents (e.g., contracts, financial records, beneficiary registration forms) are only accessible to designated staff.
- c) No unauthorized copying or removal of documents is allowed.
- d) Physical records are archived systematically and disposed of securely through shredding when no longer needed.

### **6. Soft Copy (Digital Data) Management**

- a) Digital data is stored on secure, password-protected systems, including local servers, cloud platforms, or encrypted drives.
- b) Access to sensitive files is controlled using user permissions and role-based access.
- c) Regular backups are conducted to prevent data loss.
- d) Antivirus software, firewalls, and encryption tools are used to protect against cyber threats.
- e) Laptops and USB devices carrying sensitive data must be password protected and encrypted.
- f) Staff are trained on data security protocols and digital hygiene.

### **7. Data Sharing and Transmission**

- a) Data sharing must follow the principle of minimum necessary access.

- b) Any sharing of personal or sensitive information must be authorized and documented.
- c) Data shared externally (e.g., with donors or partners) must be anonymized when required.
- d) Email attachments containing sensitive data must be encrypted or password protected.

## **8. Staff Responsibilities**

- a) All Harikar personnel are expected to handle data responsibly and in accordance with this policy.
- b) Any suspected or actual data breach must be reported immediately to the Data Protection Focal Point or IT Officer.
- c) Staff receive regular training and updates on data protection and security practices.

## **9. Data Breach Management**

Harikar is committed to responding promptly and effectively to any actual or suspected data breach in order to minimize harm to affected individuals, protect organizational information assets, and comply with applicable legal and donor requirements.

### **9.1 Definition of a Data Breach**

A data breach is any accidental or unlawful destruction, loss, alteration, unauthorized disclosure of, or unauthorized access to personal, confidential, or sensitive information, whether in electronic or physical form. Examples include, but are not limited to:

- Loss or theft of laptops, mobile devices, USB drives, or paper files containing sensitive information.
- Sending confidential information to an unauthorized recipient.
- Unauthorized access to Harikar's information systems or databases.
- Malware, ransomware, phishing, or other cyberattacks resulting in data compromise.
- Accidental deletion or corruption of important organizational data.

### **9.2 Identification and Reporting**

Any staff member, volunteer, consultant, or contractor who becomes aware of a suspected or actual data breach shall:

- a) Immediately take reasonable steps to prevent further loss or unauthorized disclosure, where it is safe and practical to do so.
- b) Report the incident without delay to the Data Protection Focal Point and the IT Officer, and inform their immediate supervisor.
- c) Provide all available information, including:
  - Date and time of the incident;

- Nature of the breach;
- Type of data affected;
- Number of individuals potentially affected;
- Actions already taken to contain the incident.

Failure to report a known data breach may constitute a disciplinary matter.

### **9.3 Containment**

Upon receiving a breach report, the Data Protection Focal Point and IT Officer shall immediately:

- Secure affected systems or physical records.
- Disable compromised user accounts where necessary.
- Recover lost or corrupted data from available backups.
- Prevent further unauthorized access or disclosure.
- Preserve evidence required for investigation.

### **9.4 Investigation and Risk Assessment**

A breach investigation shall be initiated as soon as practicable to determine:

- The cause and circumstances of the breach.
- The categories and sensitivity of the data involved.
- The number of individuals affected.
- Whether confidentiality, integrity, or availability has been compromised.
- The potential impact on affected individuals, Harikar, donors, or partners.
- Corrective and preventive measures required.

Where appropriate, Harikar may establish an internal investigation team consisting of representatives from IT, Compliance, Human Resources, Programme, and Senior Management.

### **9.5 Notification and Response**

Where required by applicable law, donor agreements, or contractual obligations, Harikar shall promptly notify the relevant donor, partner, or competent authority of a reportable data breach. Where there is a high risk of harm to affected individuals, Harikar shall consider informing those individuals without undue delay, including guidance on measures they can take to protect themselves.

### **9.6 Corrective and Preventive Actions**

Following each confirmed breach, Harikar shall implement appropriate corrective measures, which may include:

- Updating security controls.
- Resetting passwords and access credentials.
- Applying software patches or security updates.

- Revising procedures and internal controls.
- Providing additional staff awareness or training.
- Applying disciplinary measures where negligence or misconduct contributed to the breach.

### **9.7 Documentation and Lessons Learned**

All actual and suspected data breaches shall be documented in a confidential Data Breach Register maintained by the Data Protection Focal Point.

Each record shall include:

- Date of the incident.
- Description of the breach.
- Root cause.
- Impact assessment.
- Actions taken.
- Notifications made.
- Corrective measures implemented.
- Date of closure.

Senior Management shall periodically review breach reports to identify trends, strengthen organizational controls, and improve information security practices.

### **9.8 Data Retention and Disposal**

- a) Data is retained only as long as necessary for legal, operational, or contractual reasons.
- b) Obsolete or redundant data is deleted from systems or destroyed (in the case of hard copies) in a secure manner.
- c) Retention timelines are defined in Harikar's internal archiving and records management procedures.

## **10. Policy Review and Updates**

This policy is reviewed and updated annually or as needed to reflect organizational changes, new legal requirements, or evolving best practices.

**Approved by:**



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Executive Director  
Date: 17 Dec. 2025